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The Lost Homeland

Since the death of my mother, Elfriede, ten years ago, I have been haunted by the desire to visit the homeland, the *Heimat*, that she never saw again after her fifty years in Australia. In more ways than one, Germany had become her lost homeland, the spiritual place of her ancestors from which she was exiled. I sensed the pain she felt over the tangible loss of connection to her own past. For me to be able to go so far away and pay tribute to her German home in what is now Poland, to savour the environment of her childhood, at first seemed impossible. I nevertheless hoped for the opportunity to do so, although I expected to find all the names of the places changed, and that people spoke a language I did not understand. It would be confronting to go there, I thought.

When in 1997 I visited Vienna, my father's Austrian birth city, and after that my German cousins in Germany, I was not regarded as a stranger. Despite being an almost lifelong Australian, I spoke their language and somehow belonged. I was accepted by people as someone who had come home to reclaim my heritage. I could merge with crowds unobtrusively, like a 'local'. The only subtle tremors of feeling generated by what people are used to were shown up in my too-German ways for the Austrians, and my too-Austrian ways for the Germans. The Austrians reacted more firmly. This suggests that my mother's influence on me was strongest.

I was born in Turkey, north of Ankara, in 1935, and when I also went there on my trip home, I was treated to a special welcome by each Turk who found this out, from my passport or my conversation. My birth in Turkey entitled me to Turkish citizenship. Naturally I was delighted,